company’s engineers could explain what a policy did, but not always why it existed or who was responsible for maintaining it. Governance emerged as a way to restore intent, reconnecting the technical logic of authorization with the organizational purpose behind it.

Figure 14.1 shows how this drift emerges. Organizational intent exists at the enterprise level, but without governance, it is interpreted independently by each department. Over time, policies lose clear ownership and fall out of step with one another, some becoming orphaned, others overly restrictive, and still others misaligned with operational practice. Governance restores alignment by reconnecting policies to shared intent, accountability, and review.

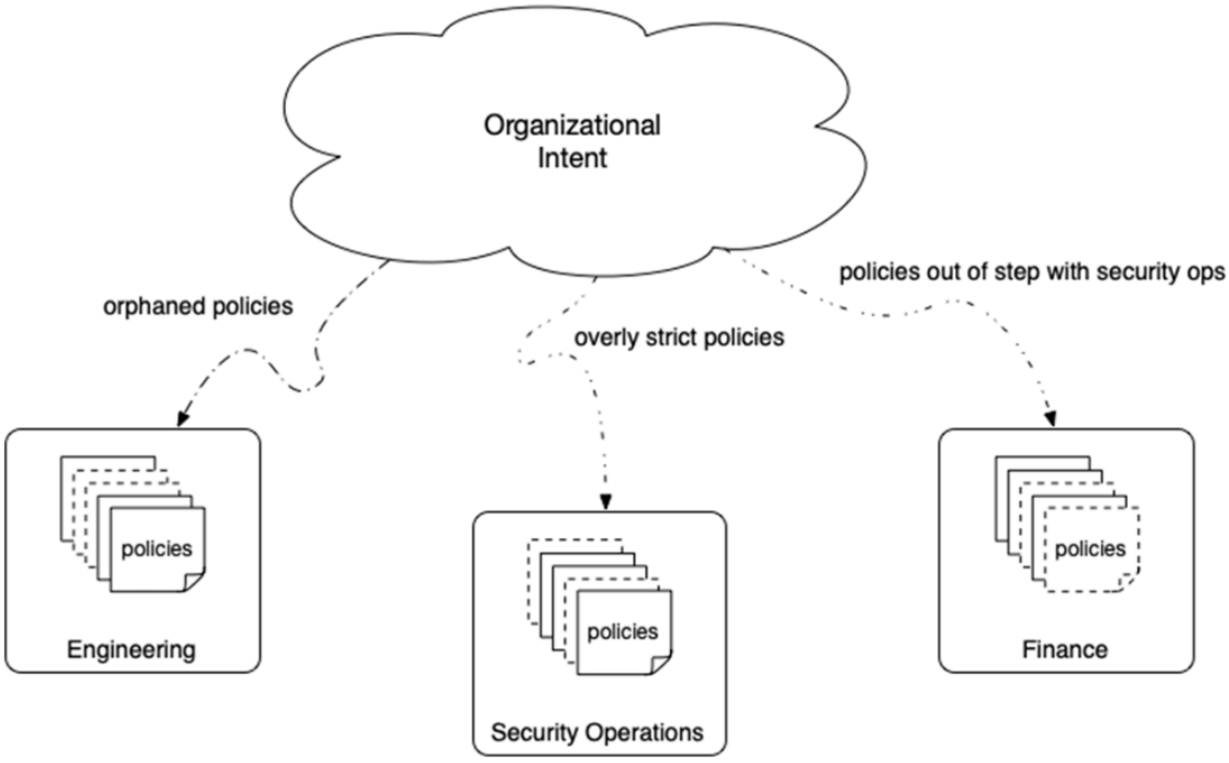


Figure 14.1 Policy drift without governance. When authorization policies are created and maintained independently across teams, their connection to organizational intent weakens. Policies may become orphaned, overly restrictive, or misaligned with operational realities, even when each policy appears correct within its local context.

Governance matters because authorization is not just a technical control but an *expression of institutional will*. Policies turn principles like least privilege, fairness, or compliance into executable code. Without governance, those principles can drift away. Over time, policies become inconsistent,